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Becoming a Digital Nomad: Identity Emergence in the Flow of Practice

Short Paper

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Abstract

Digital technologies have redefined many jobs and are challenging how people define themselves at work. Scholars have long argued that people's work identities are mainly derived from the organizational environment in which they are embedded. But advances in digital technologies, in combination with a global restructuring of labor markets, have led a large segment of the workforce into alternative work arrangements outside of traditional, hierarchical corporations. Understanding work-related identities and in particular the ways in which they emerge thus becomes an important topic in the context of digital work. Building on an ethnographic study of digital nomads, this research-in-progress shows that digital workers, not associated with an organization or profession, are nonetheless able to construct work identities. Our preliminary findings illustrate how identity is emerging in the flow between two opposing practices and how this flow is continuously shaped by material, spatial, and temporal forces.

Keywords: Digital nomadism, digital work, identity, ethnography, flow of practice, Ingold

Introduction

Digital work is becoming indispensable for contemporary jobs and work practices (Colbert et al. 2016; Orlikowski and Scott 2016). One such digital work practice that is emerging as a new form of digital and location-independent work is digital nomadism (Jarrahi et al. 2019; Schlagwein 2018). Digital nomads (DNs) are individuals who leverage technology to work remotely and live an independent and nomadic lifestyle (Nash et al. 2018). For DNs, this extreme mobility and organizational independence pose new challenges to making sense of what work means to them and how they define themselves at work (Ens et al. 2018; Reichenberger 2017). Understanding work-related identities and in particular the ways in which they emerge thus becomes an important topic in the context of digital work (Barley et al. 2017).

The literature on work identity has focused on questions concerning meanings in relation to work-related activities and role, leading to the notion of professional, occupational, and organizational identities (Ashforth et al. 2008). While scholars have originally studied work identity as something stable and static (Albert and Whetten 1985), recent scholarly research has revealed and examined the changing nature of identities (Caza et al. 2018). Such a dynamic view of identity enabled a better understanding of the causes of identity change and why individuals engage in activities to construct, maintain, or give up identities (Schultz and Hernes 2013). Although this literature has made important contributions to understanding

identity construction at work, there is a need to go beyond exploring the causes of identity dynamics and expand research into the process of identity emergence (Alvesson et al. 2008; Boudreau et al. 2014).

Clearly, digital technologies play an important role in the identity construction of contemporary professionals pursuing highly digitized, independent, and often pluralistic careers. DNs are pushing this way of working to the extreme. With digital technologies permeating every aspect of these workers' lives, it becomes unconvincing to assume a conceptualization of identity that is exclusively situated within the human, independent of the technological and material surroundings (Orsatti and Riemer 2015). However, there is a paucity of studies investigating how digital technologies and the material practices in which they are enacted configure work identity emergence (Whitley et al. 2014). As a result, scholars have been calling to examine the role new technologies and material artefacts play in the ways identities emerge in ongoing enactments of work practices (Carter 2015; Knights and Clarke 2017).

Existing literature in Information Systems (IS) and Organization Studies investigating identity in the workplace anticipates that DNs – workers not associated with an organization and/or profession – have difficulties developing an identity. A strong organizational culture and the tight relationships inside a traditional corporation have been deemed necessary to construct a stable work identity (Pratt et al. 2006; Stein et al. 2013). However, in our empirical study of DNs, we found – on the contrary – that highly self-sufficient, location-independent workers, who are lacking a stable institutional attachment, do develop work identities, making meaning of themselves and their professional roles. In line with existing research on digital nomadism (Sutherland and Jarrahi 2017), but contrary to existing theories of identity, there appear to be processes of identity emergence at work that challenge our current understanding of identity and identity work. To address this theoretical gap in the literature, we sought to explain the process of identity emergence among DNs. We focused our study on examining the following research question: *How do work identities of digital nomads emerge?*

To answer this question, we report on an ongoing ethnographic study of DNs. Focusing on identity emergence and the ways workers construct their identities – often referred to as ‘identity work’ – we subscribe to a processual view of identity, based on a relational ontology (Cecez-Kecmanovic 2016; Nayak and Chia 2011). Of particular interest in our study are the material/technological, spatial, and temporal facets enacting a process of identity emergence that is decentered from the human subject. We are currently at the stage of iteratively developing theory based on the in-depth qualitative study. We present here some preliminary findings that demonstrate how the practices of identity work are performed in a continuous cycle of identity emergence. Before we do that, we discuss conceptual foundations and our research method in the following sections.

Literature Review

Digital Work, Digital Nomadism, and Related Concepts

With the rapid advances in digital technologies that we have witnessed over the past decade, many work practices are being reconfigured as digital work (Colbert et al. 2016; Orlikowski and Scott 2016). Technologies such as mobile internet, cloud computing, and artificial intelligence promise workplace flexibility and autonomy through automation and location-independent working arrangements (Ens et al. 2018). Yet, scholars have raised concerns about precarious working conditions and loss of workplace security, creating not only opportunities but also risks for digital workers (Petriglieri et al. 2019).

DNs are one group of location-independent workers taking advantage of the flexibility afforded by digital technologies (Jarrahi et al. 2019). Digital work enables DNs to perform work from almost anywhere in the world (Nash et al. 2018). While sharing some characteristics with other types of remote workers, DNs are unique in the sense that they combine their professional independence with a lifestyle of perpetual international travel and expat living (Wang et al. 2018). This means that they are blurring and balancing their personal and recreational time with their professional lives in order to pursue a career of exotic world travel and nomadic working (Reichenberger 2017).

DNs are similar to other mobile (Wang et al. 2018), location-independent (Petriglieri et al. 2019), remote, and tele workers (Ashford et al. 2018) in the sense that they typically perform digital work practices not co-located with an organization or its workers. However, their global adventure travel and dependence on contingent work, position them as a new and unique form of mobile work. Although more and more

workers are becoming mobile, DNs show extreme levels of mobility oftentimes entirely abandoning the concept of a fixed space to work or live. They rarely stay in one location for longer than a few weeks and rely on on-demand infrastructure such as co-working spaces and Airbnb (Reichenberger 2017). What sets DNs apart from more conventional mobile and tele workers is their complete independence of traditional corporations by means of working as freelancers or entrepreneurs, running their own business. DNs are typically doing contract work for corporate clients that allows them to work from anywhere in the world or are part of a digital organization that works entirely remotely without a physical office space (Sutherland and Jarrahi 2017).

Research on digital nomadism has focused on the interplay of work and leisure, and the motivating factors for choosing this digital working arrangement (Reichenberger 2017; Schlagwein 2018). The ways in which people become DNs, their personal trajectory, and the identities they develop in pursuing this new way of working and living have largely been neglected. However, understanding the emergence of work identities among DNs is becoming more important with the increasing interest in location-independent working arrangements and the decline of traditional hierarchically-organized jobs (Colbert et al. 2016). A range of blog posts, guidelines on social media, and instructions on digital platforms offer practitioner guidance for aspiring DNs. Yet, in-depth studies of digital workers' identities are imperative to build meaningful scholarship about the practices of contemporary work (Barley et al. 2017).

The rise of digital nomadism, a global workforce trend largely neglected by scholars so far, thus presents an opportunity to examine a facet of work identity that remains fairly obscure. Independent workers' ability to develop a legitimate work identity has been characterized as challenging (Petriglieri et al. 2019). The requirement of a strong institutional background to construct an identity is reflected in our existing theories of identity (Ashforth et al. 2008). On the contrary, however, DNs – a group of extremely independent workers without any institutional backing – have been described as having a strong self-identity (Sutherland and Jarrahi 2017). This theoretical gap positions the process of identity construction as a particularly interesting aspect of the DN phenomenon.

Information Technology (IT) and Identity Construction

Many disciplines have studied the concept of identity providing answers to questions such as “Who am I?” or “Who are we?”. Reflecting on these questions helps us understand how people construct and present identities in a variety of contexts, such as personal identities (Alvesson et al. 2008), professional identities (Pratt et al. 2006), and organizational identities (Albert and Whetten 1985). As scholars have theorized concepts of identity and self, they have based their explanations on three philosophical approaches that we refer to as: humanist essentialist, humanist processual, and post-humanist processual.

Albert and Whetten (1985) have originally defined identity as a stable and distinctive characteristic that workers derive from their organization. Following this essentialist ontology, most research in the IS and organization studies literature have theorized identity as a fixed, permanent feature of a distinct, self-contained individual (Alvesson et al. 2008; Carter 2015). Thus, by separating the inner self from the outside work, the human subject is afforded the privilege of being considered the unchanging locus of control, intentionality, and agency (Orsatti and Riemer 2015).

However, scholars have criticized this view of identity for paying little attention to the ways in which identities are continuously being re-enacted in the fluid and fast-changing world that we live in (Alvesson et al. 2008; Ashforth et al. 2008). A growing body of literature has thus adopted a processual view of identity as unstable and always already in becoming (Boudreau et al. 2014; Schultz and Hernes 2013; Stein et al. 2013). Therefore, the term ‘identity work’ has been coined to embrace this processual view and to describe the activities and practices concerned with continuously enacted identities (Caza et al. 2018).

What both strands of identity research have in common, however, is their anthropocentric point of departure that privileges human actors (vis-à-vis non-human actors) and foregrounds associated human agency in conceptualizing identity work (Hultin and Introna 2019). Although the IS literature has been more active in theorizing material artefacts such as IT in relation to work identity (Carter 2015; Whitley et al. 2014), most of this research has subscribed to an essentialist understanding of identity framing humans and IT as distinct, self-contained entities (Orsatti and Riemer 2015; Stein et al. 2013). As a result, scholars have recently called for a view that decenters the human actor to examine how identities are emerging within material-discursive practices (Hultin and Introna 2019; Knights and Clarke 2017).

In responding to these calls, we regard identity as always already emerging and enacted within everyday work practices and seek to answer the research question: *How do work identities of digital nomads emerge?* To do that we conducted an ethnographic research study, which is well suited to explore such processual phenomena and appreciates the richness of practice (Van Maanen 1988).

Research Method

Our (ongoing) ethnographic study (Van Maanen 1988) investigates emerging identities of DNs following a “strong” process approach (Nayak and Chia 2011) combined with a sociomaterial perspective (Cecez-Kecmanovic 2016). We describe here our data collection and inductive analysis grounded in the empirical data (Charmaz 2006).

Data Collection

To develop an in-depth understanding of DNs’ processes of identity emergence, we used participant observation, interviews, and online platforms as sources of data, collected in the period between July 2018 and April 2019. DNs work remotely from co-working spaces, coffee shops, public libraries, or recreational vehicles and constantly change their place of working and living (Reichenberger 2017). They often choose to work from locations that combine the benefits of the low cost of living with exotic environments and warm climate, such as Southeast Asia, Eastern Europe, or South America (Nash et al. 2018). Due to the mobile nature of the phenomenon, with many DNs staying less than four weeks in one location, we chose to conduct a multi-site ethnographic study at three key DN locations – Bangkok and Chiang Mai in Thailand as well as Bali in Indonesia.

We observed DNs and their daily work processes in their native environment at cafés and co-working spaces over a period of eight weeks resulting in a total of 264 hours of observation. Observing them during a full working day, we captured as much data as possible, writing field notes in real-time. In addition to taking field notes, we documented workspaces, technology setups, and ordinary work practices in 209 photographs. Being in the field, we not only observed the DNs’ interactions at work, but also participated in social events such as workshops, lunches, and after-work drinks. As such, we were able to follow DNs across spatial, social, and temporal boundaries (Van Maanen 1988).

We conducted 27 formal interviews each lasting between 37 and 107 minutes. Interviews were semi-structured in format with questions being adjusted over the course of the study to account for emerging analytical themes (Charmaz 2006). During interviews, we asked participants to describe their typical workday, recount their personal trajectory of becoming a DN, and explain key events and interactions they experienced. Our participants were typically high-skilled professionals including individuals from a wide spectrum of vocations from digital marketers, graphic designers, software developers, writers, and entrepreneurs to lifestyle coaches, lawyers, and social activists. The DNs we interviewed ranged from age 23 to 56 and included 14 women and 13 men. Most participants stated a Western country such as the USA, Canada, Netherlands, France, Germany, Australia as their country of origin.

Lastly, we supplemented our primary data (i.e., observation and interviews) with secondary data on the DN phenomenon more broadly. We collected data from the two largest online DN communities on Facebook and Reddit with 102,000 and 395,000 members respectively. To triangulate our primary data and to deepen our understanding, we filtered the discussions by searching for topics related to “identity”, “self” and “becoming a digital nomad”. We collected a total of 397 online discussions that helped us to develop an initial understanding of what digital nomadism is about.

Data Analysis

Our analytical work followed an inductive theory-generation process using grounded theory techniques (Charmaz 2006). Subscribing to the relational ontology and temporality of process research (Cecez-Kecmanovic 2016; Nayak and Chia 2011), our analysis involved an iterative process of moving between the data, literature, and emerging theory. Data analysis occurred in repeated cycles of three stages.

In the first stage of analysis, we reconstructed each DN’s personal trajectory using interview transcripts and observations collected in the field. We mapped this process of becoming a DN in rich memos (Charmaz 2006) and detailed genealogical narratives (Hultin 2019), that is, the historical-contingent

conditions of a DN's becoming through time. Starting from the work practices observed in the field, we then traced back the DN's personal trajectories to reveal the constitutive conditions that afforded the present way of working and living and their becoming digital nomads (Hultin 2019).

In the second stage, we conducted a thematic analysis of the detailed memos, the genealogical maps, and the field notes to inductively identify open codes (Charmaz 2006). Codes described practices such as workday organizing, settling in, travelling, planning, working for clients, and networking, as well as how these practices have changed over the course of becoming a DN, such as reliance on routines, upskilling, focus on experiences, and workplace automation. Open coding the data surfaced prevalent codes that helped us become deeply familiar with each DN's genealogy as an individual case, but also with the dynamic processes that were collectively enacted. The data collected online were also coded in that way to substantiate the emerging open codes. Our analysis then transitioned from rich descriptions to more analytical categories (Charmaz 2006). We merged our first-order open codes into more refined categories through repeated cycles of focused coding. This is where the practices of autonomy and stability emerged as opposing poles in a generative cycle.

In the third stage, we then developed theoretical explanations from our analytical categories and genealogical maps through moving between the literature, data, and emerging theory (Charmaz 2006). We use notions of becoming (Nayak and Chia 2011), sociomaterial processes (Cecez-Kecmanovic 2016), and the theory of correspondence (Ingold 2017) to inform our emerging theoretical model of decentered identity work. This led to our preliminary model of decentered identity emergence based on Ingold's (2015) metaphor of the river as the flow of practice along lines.

Preliminary Findings

The preliminary findings of our study on emerging identities of DNs suggest that there were two main types of practices at work that DNs engaged in to construct their identities: gaining professional autonomy and maintaining self-assured stability. The DNs we studied were subjected to and continue to undergo cycles of these two practices as opposing poles, which were generative in the sense that work identities emerged from the continuous interplay of these two practices as DNs moved between autonomy and stability. We present quotes and fieldnotes that illustrate these practices and highlight how it is not only agential human workers that form their identities, but that there are material, spatial, and temporal forces at play that perform the individual's identity.

Gaining Professional Autonomy

The individuals' quest for flexibility and autonomy at work emerged as a pervasive theme from our data. One DN argued that he is "creating this independence at so many different layers". Indeed, participants referred not only to professional, but also technological, geographical, and temporal independence.

DNs commonly work with a broad range of different technologies to gain autonomy in their professional and personal lives. They develop software on open source ecosystems (e.g., GitHub), find their next side gig on digital labor markets (e.g., Upwork), and manage their personal and professional lives using agile project management tools (e.g., Trello). Especially when developing their own startups, DNs use IT to not only support their business but sometimes also to fully automate certain work tasks. As one DN explained when describing technologies used at her own startup:

"The sales job is very simple. It's using Zoom. I'm using HubSpot as our CRM so I can call people from my computer and then Slack. There's other tools but that's kind of like the major bit. So, yeah, I mean with the small business, there's always a million tools, right? So, I've got apps that run my calendar for me. I've got robots that run my social media for me. I've got the website popups, landing pages, membership pages, and video editor. Like there's just a million different things. I think I probably have like 20 different computer programs for my company alone." (DN 12)

Other DNs also emphasized that they existentially depend on and employ a plethora of tools to run their startups. This goes beyond other types of remote workers, who also depend on mobile technologies to enable work practices distant from the main office, who can, however, more easily switch to other types of information infrastructure. These technologies afford not only flexibility with regards to where and when work is conducted, but also provide autonomy due to automation of routine and admin tasks.

Technological and location independence are intertwined, as many DNs take advantage of the workplace flexibility afforded by IT. Location becomes relatively unimportant for the types of work that DNs do and how they do it, and instead, they focus on inspiration and communication. For most DNs, creativity and innovative problem-solving are crucial traits fueled by something that one DN referred to as a “creative stimulus”.

“So, for me, I get creative when I’m outside. And when I see other people’s perspective, how they work, their culture. [...] I have a hybrid approach because I just cannot mentally work in only one place. It is one of the reasons why I also nomad now. I change locations both at the macro and micro level because I just need that stimulus.” (DN 5)

We observed this continuous inspiration gained from being location independent on many different levels. By definition, DNs frequently changed the country or city from which they worked. However, as the quote suggests, they also changed their workspace within cities moving between co-working spaces, coffee shops, and apartment rooms.

The choice of workspace also comes along with working time flexibility. Remote work is not typically governed by traditional managerial control mechanisms. Workers focus more on actual work output and productivity. DNs have the autonomy to choose when they want to work and for how long. For example, they often choose to work long hours to be able to take a few days off the following week and spend time exploring their surroundings. Overcoming the traditional idea of working time helps DNs gain autonomy from “time-boxing” activities as one DN explains:

“I used to bring a lot of the remnants of the old job like coming into an office at nine and been working until five o’clock and trying to time-box all of that within that timeframe. And it just wasn’t working for me because I found that I wasn’t always productive at the same time of the day. I didn’t have the same energy level, the same focus level. And it has always been a challenge.” (DN 13)

Comparing their past in corporate office jobs with their new way of working independently, DNs refer to the “illusion of work time” as something that limits creativity and productivity. Several instances were observed that showed how every working day of a DN is different. Although workers seemingly strive for having this flexibility and changing working conditions, DNs also make an effort to hold on to the few sources of structure available to them.

Maintaining Self-assured Stability

Despite their continuous relocation necessitated by their endeavor for continuous inspiration, DNs nevertheless put effort into maintaining a stable work environment. “I do crave, in a sense, that stability because you do at a time get exhausted”, noted a DN reflecting on his continuous relocation. Lacking the strong organizational, occupational, and institutional support, most DNs we studied had to rely on themselves to cultivate those stabilizing practices. These practices included the use of IT, the setup of workspaces, and the structure of work hours.

While participants reported technological independence as being key for professional autonomy, we also observed converse effects: that IT affords some sense of stability for DNs. For many, technology has become an indispensable tool not only for connecting to clients and producing work but also for staying connected to their family and friends. Certain IT provided anchor points for DNs that helped them cope with the constantly changing work environment that they find themselves in. One participant compared her use of technology during the time as a corporate worker with her new way of working:

“[IT] is like breathing because this is the only thing that connects you to your colleagues, your company, your team, your family, your friends, to everyone. And so, this is so strange to think that, for example, when I have a meeting, a Skype call, I’m always on time, and I’m pissed off when people are just five minutes late. But in my company, I was always late. I was always 10 minutes late to every meeting. But here because this is the only thing that relates me to my world over there, it’s very important for me.” (DN 16)

This quote illustrates a recurrent theme, that of the changing role of technology at work. Although the type of work that our participants were doing mostly did not require any special IT, the ways how workers

were using IT in their daily lives changed substantially. Lacking the direct support of employers, DNs created stability and structure through other sources, such as digital technologies.

During the weeks of fieldwork observation, we were able to observe a range of different routines and rituals that participants engaged in to balance the intricacies of their work, especially about their construction of the workspace. Indeed, spaces were actively shaped by workers through meticulous desk setups, morning rituals, or routine occupations of the favorite seat in the co-working space as discussed in this dialogue (Field notes observation 42):

“Co-working space staff:	It’s good to be back after two months. But you two are still sitting in the exact same spot that I left you in two months ago. Have you moved out of here at all recently?
Digital nomad couple (laughing):	We like our two seats and little desk by the window. We sometimes even just keep our laptops here when we go home.
Co-working space staff:	It’s good to have some kind of a routine at work, isn’t it?
Digital nomad couple:	Absolutely, we really enjoy coming in in the morning without having to think about where we want to sit today.”

Routines helped participants maintain a sense of stability while being location-independent at the same time. Many DNs described routines as something that they hold on to no matter where they are in the world. With an effective set of routines digital workers, we observed, were able to keep up high levels of productivity and shield themselves from distractions irrespective of the particular workspace that they chose for the day.

Most DNs described the importance of strict workday planning and highly disciplined time management, despite emphasizing the benefits of being able to independently choose very flexible conditions with regards to when and how long to work. Since many participants emphasized the role of productivity and actual work output when working independently, keeping productivity levels high and being able to self-reflect on one’s work output emerged as a prominent theme from our data:

“I’m a person that wants to know his working hours. I think a lot of people sort of feel how much work they’re doing at the end of the day and I’m like, at the end of the day, how much actual work did I get done? I want to know. And so, I wanted to track that so I can look back. My numbers right now, I was just reviewing them last night, are saying that I’m working between 28 to 35 actual hours of work time a week.” (DN 13)

The contrast between the temporal flexibility implied in this quote and the stringent management of work hours captures a seemingly paradoxical perception of working time. Despite the flexibility with regards to working time afforded by digital and location-independent work, participants self-imposed structured working hours to maintain their productivity.

Toward a Theory of Decentered Identity Emergence

Based on our preliminary findings, we propose that DNs’ identities emerge through the interplay between two opposing practices, as visualized in Figure 1. On the one hand, DNs are seeking flexibility, independence, and professional autonomy and on the other are trying to establish a work structure and achieve some sense of stability. Figure 1 illustrates how DNs enact a cycle of trying to gain professional autonomy and maintain their stability. They continuously work towards these practices as opposing poles, but never achieve an ultimate state of autonomy or stability. We find evidence that this continuous cycle is truly generative in the sense that the flow and interplay between these two practices constitute the source of identity emergence (Ingold 2015). In this account, identity work is, however, not exclusively performed by human actors, but is shaped by material, spatial, and temporal forces. We have shown with our findings how exemplary forces such as, digital technologies (e.g., Skype), workplaces (e.g., co-working spaces), and working hours (e.g., time zone management) are performing the DN identity in a way that goes beyond intentional human identity work. This unwinding of the generative cycle as the flow of practice along a line provides the grounds for identity to emerge (Ingold 2017).

To summarize, based on our preliminary findings, we posit that DNs’ identities emerge along the flow and through the interplay between opposing work practices. This suggests that the continuous identifying movement between gaining professional autonomy and maintaining self-assured stability is not only

shaped by an intentional human actor but is always already shaped by the material-discursive conditions that perform the DNs' work practices. Our ultimate aim is to contribute to the IS, Management and Organization Studies literature concerned with identity construction and the future of work. With this, we develop a decentered understanding of identity emergence that takes materials, technologies, space, and time into consideration in the continuous becoming of digital workers. With this we provide explanations to help understand the theoretical gap in the identity literature that is challenged by new forms of working and organizing (Ashford et al. 2018; Petriglieri et al. 2019). Furthermore, we provide initial insights for prospective DNs and management practitioners looking to employ such digital workers. Specifically, we provide rich descriptions of DNs' work practices and show how traditional organizations can benefit from the DNs' flexibility while nourishing their sense of identity as independent workers.

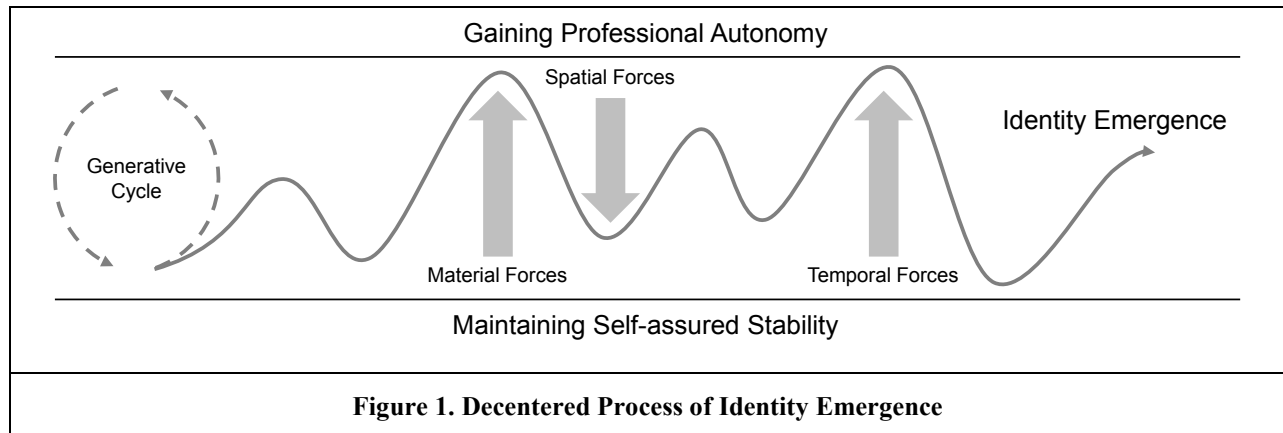


Figure 1. Decentered Process of Identity Emergence

In our future work, we plan to undertake additional data collection in key DN locations and conduct follow-up interviews with existing participants of our study. We plan to further examine the preliminary findings presented in this paper and elaborate on the emerging analytical themes. This extended field work and a more elaborate analysis of the data will enable us to engage in theorizing and further develop the process theoretical model of identity emergence among DNs.

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